

BOB INGRAM

Andy sees baseball heroics



COHEN

IT WAS the ninth inning at Tempe, Ariz., with U.T. El Paso leading. The Sun Devils, perennial champions of the Western Athletic Conference, were taking their bats.

Marc Bombard, little left hander for the Miners, was pitching. The first ASU player walked. Next batter hit a little fly over second base that went for a double. Now there were two men on base, one at third and one at second, and nobody out.

Bombard fanned the next two batters. Then Roger Schmuck came to bat. He was ASU's top hitter and had been named athlete of the year at ASU. Bombard threw the ball. Schmuck swung and missed. Twice more Schmuck waved at balls thrown by Bombard and did not connect. The inning and game were over and the Miners had won, 5-4. Winning that game was one of the most satisfying things to happen to Andy Cohen who this week announced that he's retiring as the Miner baseball coach after 16 seasons.

In Western Athletic Conference play, the Bombard win over Arizona State rates even higher than the Miners taking a series from Arizona two games to one in Tucson when the Cats were defending conference champions.

His biggest day

THE TOP thrill of Andy's career, of course, came the day he broke into the big leagues — with the New York Giants — way back there in John McGraw's days.

He was just a rookie second baseman up from Waco in the Texas League.

He won the game with two hits and was an immediate hero in New York City.

Then there was the time when he was managing Denver in the Western League. It was the last day of the season. The Denver club and Pueblo were tied for the championship. Some 19,000 Denver fans were on hand. The Denver Bears won the game and championship in the final inning. Denver fans threw cushions all over the field.

A more heralded occasion occurred in the spring of 1960. Andy was a coach on the Philadelphia team under Eddie Sawyer. The Phillies opened the season at Cincinnati and lost by a 9-4 score. Before they came home, Sawyer decided to resign. He saw the hand writing of a losing season on the wall. But the Phils won their opening home game 5-4 in 10 innings. And the manager of the team that day was Andy Cohen. He ran the club until Gene Mauch, the new manager, assumed command.

Andy Cohen's managerial record is: Won one, lost none. He was undefeated and untied. Somebody might tie it, but nobody will ever beat it.

Marc his favorite

IT'S EASY to see why Marc Bombard might be Andy's favorite all-time U.T. player.

"He was a bulldog, a player who never gave up out there on the mound," Andy said. "He looked small and that may have deceived a lot of scouts. But he had a man's body." And it goes without saying, a man's heart.

"We won seven games in the conference one season and Bombard pitched and won those seven games," Andy continued.

"I recommended Bombard to Bob Howsam of the Cincinnati Reds. They signed him and he did some no-hit pitching in Florida. The Reds thought so much of him that they've made him their minor league pitching coach."

Andy coached other players who are among his favorites. One of them is Mark Miller. "He could have made it to the big leagues. He had power from both sides of the plate and was the smoothest fielder you ever saw."

Andy will be glad to know that Bob Alsop, a member of this year's UTEP team, today was named on the Southern Division All-WAC team as an outfielder.

Andy will turn over the coaching reins to a younger man at UTEP. Andy says: "I'm not sorry I went into baseball. I loved being a player, a manager, coach and scout. I had some great times. Other times weren't so good. But the good ones outweighed the bad ones."

I guarantee that if Andy had his life to do over, he'd still want to be in baseball.